

BELMONT CREST — The Kingdom Behind the Gates

Document 04 · Locked Canon · History, Geography & Addresses

Founded 1958 by Alexander & Simone Donohue

Location & Address (LOCKED)

Item	Detail
Official name	Belmont Crest (legally The Belmont Crest Association, Inc. , a private gated community)
Main Gate address	One Belmont Crest Parkway NW, Atlanta, Georgia 30327
City / County	Inside the City of Atlanta, Fulton County , Georgia
Neighborhood	Northwest Buckhead , Atlanta's wealthiest district, inside the I-285 Perimeter
Precise location	On the wooded bluffs above the Chattahoochee River , entered from West Paces Ferry Road NW about 1.5 miles west of the Georgia Governor's Mansion. The river forms the community's entire western and northern border.
ZIP code	30327, the most affluent ZIP code in Georgia
Size	1,140 acres
Residences	212 homes, from 8,000 to 60,000+ sq. ft.
Population (2005)	About 780 residents, plus about 1,400 staff who come through the Service Gate daily
Distance	15 minutes to Donohue Tower (Peachtree Road). 20 minutes to Downtown and Midtown. 30 minutes to Hartsfield-Jackson.
Police jurisdiction	APD Zone 2 (Buckhead), plus the community's private security, contracted since 2002 to Blackwater Security International

The Gates

- **The Main Gate (the Crown Gate):** One Belmont Crest Parkway NW, off West Paces Ferry Road. Twin limestone guardhouses, 24-foot wrought-iron gates with a gilded "BC" crown crest, and a scorch mark on the left pillar that has been deliberately preserved since 1959 (see History).
 - **The Service Gate:** Off Paces Ferry Road NW. Staff, deliveries, and contractors.
 - **The River Gate:** A private dock and boathouse on the Chattahoochee. Officially closed after dark. **SECRET:** The birthplace of the Blackwater Syndicate (see Document 06).
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Neighborhoods Within Belmont Crest

Section	Character	Notable Residents
The Summit (Sovereign Way)	The highest bluff. The Donohue family compound: six estates around a private garden.	Victor & Joan, Simone, Theodore, the Olsons, the Bullocks, Marc-Anthony
Kingsridge (Kingsridge Drive)	Old-money mansions on 5–15 acre lots. Judges, moguls, surgeons, athletes.	The Cummings family
Magnolia Terrace	Smaller but elegant homes (8,000–10,000 sq ft) reserved by charter for professionals: doctors, dentists, educators, clergy.	The Baker family, Bishop Everett Lyons
Riverbend	Newer luxury homes on the Chattahoochee, built 1985–2000	New money, entertainers, executives
The Commons	Village green, chapel, Belmont Crest Academy, market, post office	Community center

Key Addresses (LOCKED)

Address	Residence	Residents
1 Sovereign Way	Donohue Manor. A 1960 Georgian Revival, 48,000 sq ft, 30 acres.	Victor & Joan Donohue
2 Sovereign Way	The Dowager House. A 1958 Creole-style mansion with wraparound galleries, the first house built in Belmont Crest.	Simone Donohue
3 Sovereign Way	Theodore's House ("Ashgrove"). A dark-brick Tudor with a vault underneath.	Theodore & Connie Donohue
9 Sovereign Way	The Olson Estate. Modern limestone, with a surgical suite in the east wing.	Peter, Jasmine, and Mallory Olson (Martin keeps a wing, plus a Midtown loft)
12 Sovereign Way	The Bullock Estate ("Belle Rive"). A Mediterranean palazzo overlooking the river.	Robert & Natasha Bullock, Grace Bullock (who also keeps an L.A. home)
25 Sovereign Way	The Bullock Pavilion. A glass-and-stone contemporary, built 2003.	Marc-Anthony Bullock
31 Sovereign Way	The Carriage House. A renovated guest estate.	Alvin Donohue (when he isn't in Miami)
41 Kingsridge Drive	The Cummings Estate	Franklin & Yvette Cummings, Arianna Cummings
214 Magnolia Terrace	The Baker Home	Dr. Curtis & Gloria Baker, Kiara Baker. Amond keeps his old room but lives in a Buckhead penthouse.
7 Chapel Lane	The Parsonage	Bishop Everett & First Lady Pearl Lyons

Address	Residence	Residents
Elxa & Jeremy	Live outside the gates on purpose, in a Virginia-Highland Craftsman at 1087 Rosedale Road NE, Atlanta 30306. Elxa refuses to "live on the family's dime" as Chief.	Chief Elxa & Det. Jeremy Jackson

Amenities

- **The Belmont Crest Country Club** (see below)
 - **Belmont Crest Chapel:** A white-stone chapel from 1959. Every family wedding and funeral happens here.
 - **Greater Crest Tabernacle:** The community's AME church, led by Bishop Everett Lyons.
 - **Belmont Crest Academy:** A private pre-K through 12 school, founded 1962. Marc-Anthony graduated at 12.
 - **Lake Simone:** A 40-acre spring-fed lake with swans, a gazebo, and a Fourth of July fireworks barge.
 - **The Crest Equestrian Center**, a 30-stall barn and polo field
 - **The River Boathouse & Dock** on the Chattahoochee
 - **The Commons Market**, a gourmet grocery, café, and pharmacy (named Toussaint's, after Simone)
 - A private **helipad** at the Summit
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THE HISTORY OF BELMONT CREST

1955–1957: The Buckhead Gambit

- In 1955 the U.S. Supreme Court rules in *Holmes v. City of Atlanta* that Atlanta's public golf courses must desegregate. On the first integrated day, a white man spits on Alexander's shoes at the North Fulton course. Alexander goes home and tells Simone: *"I'm done asking to play on their land. We'll buy our own."*
- Black families in 1950s Atlanta are pushed to the south and west side. The real estate industry quietly makes sure no white Buckhead seller will sell to a Black buyer.
- **Simone's plan:**
 - Alexander hires a young white attorney, **Harlan Whitcomb**, who hates the Klan more than he likes money.
 - Through Whitcomb and **eleven shell companies** (named after Simone's favorite flowers: Magnolia Land Co., Camellia Holdings, Jasmine Trust, and so on), the Donohues quietly buy

1,140 acres of Chattahoochee bluff forest from 23 owners over 26 months.

- The sellers think the buyer is a "Northern timber syndicate."

1958: The Founding

- **Saturday, March 15, 1958:** The deeds are consolidated. The **Belmont Crest Association, Inc.** is chartered.
 - The name comes from **Belmont**, Simone's family's plantation-era origin story (her great-grandmother was enslaved on a Louisiana estate called Belmont). **Simone insisted:** *"We will take the name they owned us under and make it mean something they can never touch."*
 - **"Crest"** is for the bluff, and for the family crown.
- **Monday, May 5, 1958:** At a press conference at the Hotel Donohue, **Alexander reveals that the owner of the largest private landholding in Buckhead is a Black man.**
 - The *Atlanta Daily World* runs the headline **"DONOHUE BUYS BUCKHEAD."**
 - White Buckhead panics.
- **Summer 1958:**
 - Groundbreaking on the **Dowager House** (then simply "Simone's House") and the **main gate**.
 - Neighbors petition the city to rezone the land as "unsuitable for residential use."
 - Harlan Whitcomb wins in court.

1959: The Fire at the Gate

- **Saturday, June 20, 1959:** Victor Donohue marries Joan Mercer, the first wedding at Belmont Crest Chapel. 600 guests attend.
- **Saturday, October 24, 1959, 1:15 AM:** Klansmen burn a 12-foot cross at the Crown Gate.
 - **Simone, 48, stands on the Dowager House porch in her nightgown with a shotgun until dawn.**
 - Theodore (25) and Victor (23) guard the gate with rifles beside her.
 - At 7:00 AM, Simone serves the reporters coffee and biscuits and says: ***"Tell them we're not going anywhere. Tell them we're just getting started."***
 - The scorched gate pillar has been preserved ever since. A bronze plaque reads: *"October 24, 1959. We stayed."*

1960s: The Kingdom Builds

- **1960:** Donohue Manor is completed. Victor and Joan move in with newborn Jasmine.
- **Saturday, April 15, 1961: The Belmont Crest Country Club opens.** It is the first Black-owned private country club in the South with a championship course.
- **1962:** Belmont Crest Academy opens.

- **1963:** The **Magnolia Terrace Charter** passes. Simone insists that 40 lots be permanently reserved and sold at cost to Black teachers, doctors, dentists, nurses, and ministers: "*A kingdom with no teachers is just a fortress.*" That's why the Bakers (a dentist and a principal) live there.
- **Throughout the Civil Rights Movement**, Belmont Crest quietly shelters movement leaders, lawyers, and entertainers in Atlanta, behind gates the Klan can't get through.

1970s–1980s: "Black Royalty"

- **1971:** *Ebony* runs a 12-page spread, "**Inside Belmont Crest: America's Black Royalty**," which gives the family its lasting nickname.
- **1974–1988:** Kingsridge and Riverbend fill with Black athletes, entertainers, judges, and executives. A home in Belmont Crest becomes the ultimate status symbol in Black America.
- **1985:** *Lifestyles of the Rich and Famous* is denied entry at the Main Gate. Robin Leach reports from the sidewalk.

1990s–2004: The Modern Era

- **1992:** Belmont Crest Academy's championship debate team, including 10-year-old Marc-Anthony Bullock, wins the national title.
- **1996:** During the Olympics, Belmont Crest hosts a private gala for 40 heads of state.
- **1999:** Alexander dies at Donohue Manor.
- **2002:** Community security is contracted to **Blackwater Security International**, the new company of 20-year-old Marc-Anthony Bullock. Crime inside the gates drops from "almost none" to **exactly none**.
- **2003:** The Bullock Pavilion is built at 25 Sovereign Way.
- **2004:** Elxa Bullock marries Jeremy Jackson at the Chapel on **October 16**.

THE BELMONT CREST COUNTRY CLUB

Item	Detail
Opened	Saturday, April 15, 1961
Clubhouse	A 110,000 sq ft Georgian clubhouse overlooking the 18th green and the river
Golf	The Sovereign Course , an 18-hole championship course, par 72, 7,420 yards. Home of the Crest Classic charity tournament every October.
Other	The Simone Ballroom (seats 900), the Alexander Grill, the Toussaint Spa, 16 tennis courts (clay and grass), an Olympic pool, and the Cigar Library
Membership	By invitation only. Initiation fee: \$500,000 (2005). Maximum 400 member families. The waiting list is 11 years long.

Item	Detail
General Manager	Percival "Percy" Langston (see Document 07)
Club President	Victor Donohue (honorary). Board chaired by Franklin Cummings.

Club Traditions (Recurring Story Events)

Event	When (2005)	Purpose
The New Year's Crown Brunch	Sunday, January 2, 2005 (the day before the premiere)	The season opener
The Founders' Ball	Saturday, March 12, 2005 (the weekend before Alexander's birthday)	Black-tie, February-sweeps aftermath
The Magnolia Cotillion	Saturday, April 30, 2005	Debutantes presented. May sweeps event.
The Juneteenth Lawn Party	Sunday, June 19, 2005	Lawn party, fireworks. Harmony's birthday.
The Fourth on the Lake	Monday, July 4, 2005	Fireworks barge on Lake Simone
The Crest Classic	Oct. 13–16, 2005	Charity golf, a November-sweeps lead-in
The Queen's Jubilee (Simone at 95)	Wednesday, November 2, 2005	Simone's 95th birthday, the November sweeps showpiece
The Christmas Crown Gala	Saturday, December 17, 2005	White-tie holiday ball

Club Rules Everybody Breaks

1. No business on the course. (Everyone does business on the course.)
2. No cell phones in the Alexander Grill. (Alvin has had four phones confiscated.)
3. Guests must be accompanied by a member. (**Esther Smiley will get in without one.**)

Life Behind the Gates: Tone Notes for Writers

- Belmont Crest is paradise with sharp edges: manicured, silent, and watching.
- Security logs every entry. **BSI controls the security logs.** That matters.
- Staff see everything. The housekeepers' and drivers' network is the fastest gossip system in Atlanta.
- The Smilleys' estate, **Ravenhurst**, sits **just outside** the gates, across the Nancy Creek ravine off West Paces Ferry Road, bordering Belmont Crest's eastern wall (see Document 05). The two families can see each other's lights at night.